PREREADING

- Can you name any old neighborhoods or villages that still exist within modern cities like Dhaka?
- What do you think happens to small communities when cities expand?
- Why might people want to stay in the same area even as the environment changes around them?

Ulan Daspara: **Remnants of a fishing village in Dhaka**

- Based on this title, what do you think the article is about?
- What kind of changes might have taken place in this village?
- Who do you think still lives there, and how might their lives have changed?

Once a thriving fishing village, Ulan Daspara stands today as one of Dhaka's oldest surviving settlements. Amid urban chaos, its residents hold on to memories, land and a shared legacy

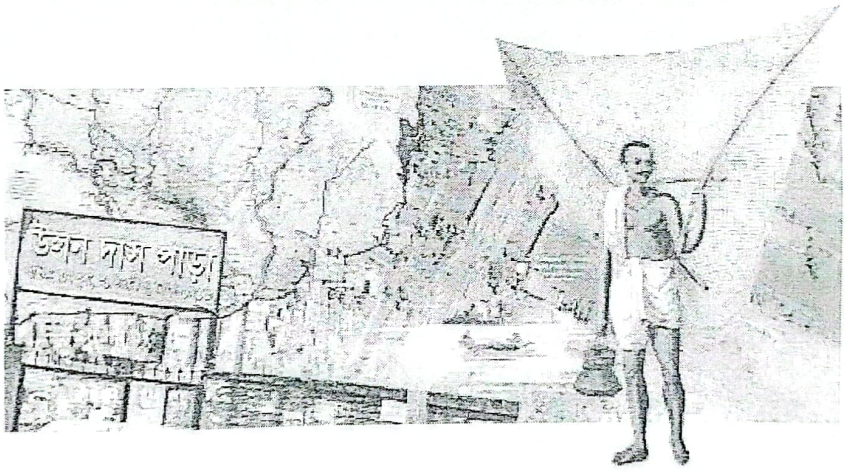


*Illustration: TBS*

*READING*

**Write the *main idea* of all the paragraphs in phrases in the space given before each of them**

Introduction

Cities oldest ~~settlement~~.

Ulan Daspara, nestled within Rampura, Dhaka, stands as one of the city's oldest surviving settlements. Originally a fishing hamlet straddling the Naraai River, it is now a compact neighborhood of around 50–55 houses on 4–5 bighas, housing about 350 residents—primarily descendants of the Hindu Das community.

History

Ulan refers to a local mouza (land unit), and the "Daspara" section extends along Ulan Road, from Molla Tower to Rampura Bazar. The Das families trace their lineage back six or seven generations. They relocated from Kunipara near Tejgaon, where present-day Aarong stands, to escape development pressures roughly 150–200 years ago. Land loss has been a recurring issue. During the Liberation War, many fled; later in 2008–

09, road expansions for Hatirjheel and construction of the TV Centre claimed over 10 bighas—shrinking the settlement significantly.

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Livelyhood Change

While fishing once defined daily life—from rainy-season river work to farming in dry seasons—pollution and urbanization eventually annihilated the local fish supply. The Naraai River, once teeming with life, morphed into souped-up urban waterways like Hatirjheel. Fishing has all but vanished, with only a few elderly fishers remaining. In response, residents pivoted to fish trading: importing from Karwan Bazar and Swaree Ghat. Over time, many have also diversified—lifting into grocery retail, furniture, garment work, and other trades .

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Story of dwellers

Take the story of Sanjit Chandra Das, born in 1983. He quit school early after his father's death, now runs a small grocery shop, and lives in a five-room concrete home with two brothers, sister, wife, son, and elderly mother. He's determined his son continues education beyond his own Class 9 cutoff. Kajolrani, a 20-year widow with five sons and three daughters, recalls her late husband's fish-selling routine in Karwan Bazar. Now her sons work varied jobs—signaling the shift from a single-occupation community. Still, extended families often converge for meals or celebrations, while weddings have moved from home courtyards to banquet halls or temples. Somparani, originally from Savar, has lived here 50 years. She upholds daily routines—prayers and chores before dawn, family meals, grandchildren's homework, and evening gatherings in the courtyard.

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Infra-structure

The architectural landscape is a mix: tin-roofed shacks, single-story brick homes, and a handful of multi-story structures like the six-floor "Manoranjan Villa" next to the Sri Kali Temple. The villa's owner, Anolkantri, and his siblings still trade fish, maintaining ties to their ancestral profession. Education has surged: roughly 90% of the younger generation hold university degrees, including women finding economic independence—a dramatic leap from the village's fisher-folk roots.

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Unity

Despite upheavals—war, riots, and the July Uprising—the community remained intact. Notably, during temple-targeted attacks, Muslim neighbors protected the Hindu residents, cementing interfaith solidarity.

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Although land was freed up after the TV Centre and university arose, these families chose continuity over relocation. Land holdings now average around half to one katha per family, and many believe that smaller homes in a stable, ancestral community are worth more than larger modern homes elsewhere.

Read each statement carefully and decide whether it is True or False based on the text summary. Circle your answer.

1. Ulan Daspara is located in the northern outskirts of Dhaka.
   True / False ✓
2. The community of Ulan Daspara originally came from Tejgaon.
   ✓ True / False
3. Fishing is still the primary occupation of most Daspara residents.
   True / False ✓

4. Road expansion and infrastructure projects reduced the size of the village.
   True / False

5. Kajolrani's family continues to fish and sell at Karwan Bazar.
   True / False

6. Education has become more important for the younger generation in the community.
   True / False

7. The residents of Daspara faced communal violence and received no support.
   True / False

8. Most residents have moved away from Daspara to larger houses in other areas.
   True / False

9. Some homes in Daspara have been rebuilt as multi-story buildings.
   True / False

10. Despite urban changes, the community of Daspara values staying connected to its heritage.
    True / False

POST READING

Discussion Questions:

1. How has Ulan Daspara changed over the years?
    - What are some of the biggest changes in people's lives and jobs?
2. Why do you think the residents of Daspara chose to stay, even after losing land or opportunities?
    - Would you do the same if you were in their place? Why or why not?
3. How does this story compare to your own neighborhood or family history?
    - Do you know of any communities in your area that have experienced similar changes?
4. What do you think are the benefits and challenges of living in an old, traditional community in a modern city?
5. In your opinion, what does it mean to "belong" to a place?
    - Can someone feel connected to a place even if they no longer live there?